20261015 Quiz

for (MATH261) Discrete Mathematics

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Problem 1. Let $m, n \in \mathbb{N}$.

(a) Let $k_1, \dots, k_m \in \mathbb{N}$ with $k_1 + \cdots + k_m = n$. Prove that

$$\binom{n}{k_1, k_2, \dots, k_m} = \sum_{j=1}^{m} \binom{n-1}{k_1, \dots, k_j - 1, \dots, k_m}.$$

(b) Prove the multinomial theorem by induction on n: for arbitrary $x_1, \dots, x_m \in \mathbb{R}$,

$$(x_1 + \cdots + x_m)^n = \sum_{\substack{k_1+\cdots+k_m=n \\ k_1,\dots,k_m \in \mathbb{N}_0}} \binom{n}{k_1, \dots, k_m} x_1^{k_1} \cdots x_m^{k_m}.$$

Solution.

(a) Count the strings of length n containing exactly k_j copies of the symbol j for each $j \in [m]$. The total number of such strings is

$$\binom{n}{k_1, k_2, \dots, k_m}.$$

Classify these strings according to their last symbol. If the last symbol is j, then the first $n-1$ positions contain $k_j - 1$ copies of j and k_i copies of each $i \neq j$, giving

$$\binom{n-1}{k_1, \dots, k_j - 1, \dots, k_m}$$

strings. The m cases are disjoint and exhaustive, so summing them gives the desired identity.

(b) We use induction on n. For $n = 1$,

$$x_1 + \cdots + x_m = \sum_{j=1}^{m} x_j,$$

which is the multinomial formula in the base case.
Assume the formula holds for some $n \in \mathbb{N}$. Multiplying the induction hypothesis by $x_1 + \cdots + x_m$, consider a monomial

$$x_1^{\ell_1} \cdots x_m^{\ell_m}, \qquad \ell_1 + \cdots + \ell_m = n + 1.$$

Its coefficient is

$$\sum_{\substack{1\le j\le m\\ \ell_j>0}} \binom{n}{\ell_1,\dots,\ell_j-1,\dots,\ell_m}.$$

Using the factorial formula for multinomial coefficients,

$$\begin{aligned}\sum_{\substack{1\le j\le m\\ \ell_j>0}} \binom{n}{\ell_1,\dots,\ell_j-1,\dots,\ell_m} &= \frac{n!}{\ell_1!\cdots\ell_m!}\sum_{j=1}^{m}\ell_j\\ &= \frac{(n+1)!}{\ell_1!\cdots\ell_m!}\\ &= \binom{n+1}{\ell_1,\dots,\ell_m}.\end{aligned}$$

Therefore the multinomial formula holds for $n+1$, and hence for every $n\in\mathbb{N}$ by mathematical induction.

□

Problem 2. There are 10 couples, each with one child. The 10 children are lost in a dark cave, and each couple retrieves exactly one child, so that every child is retrieved once. How many assignments pair at least one child with their own parents?

Solution. Label the couples and their children by $[10]$, with child i belonging to couple i. An assignment of the children to the couples is a permutation of $[10]$. For $i\in[10]$, let A_i be the set of assignments in which couple i retrieves child i.

If k specified couples are correctly paired, then the remaining $10-k$ children may be assigned arbitrarily to the remaining couples, giving $(10-k)!$ assignments. Hence, by inclusion-exclusion,

$$\begin{aligned}|A_1\cup\cdots\cup A_{10}| &= \sum_{k=1}^{10}(-1)^{k+1}\binom{10}{k}(10-k)!\\ &= 10!\sum_{k=1}^{10}\frac{(-1)^{k+1}}{k!}\\ &= 2{,}293{,}839.\end{aligned}$$

□

Problem 3. Find the number of integer solutions of

$$x_1+x_2+x_3+x_4=15$$

satisfying

$$2\le x_1\le 6,\qquad -2\le x_2\le 1,\qquad 0\le x_3\le 6,\qquad 3\le x_4\le 8.$$

Hint. Use the inclusion-exclusion principle.

Solution. Set

$$y_1=x_1-2,\qquad y_2=x_2+2,\qquad y_3=x_3,\qquad y_4=x_4-3.$$

Then

$$y_1+y_2+y_3+y_4=12,$$

with

$$0\le y_1\le 4,\qquad 0\le y_2\le 3,\qquad 0\le y_3\le 6,\qquad 0\le y_4\le 5.$$

Without the upper bounds, stars and bars gives

$$\binom{12+4-1}{4-1} = \binom{15}{3}$$

nonnegative solutions.

Let A_i be the set of solutions violating the upper bound on y_i. The single intersections have sizes

$$|A_1| = \binom{10}{3}, \quad |A_2| = \binom{11}{3}, \quad |A_3| = \binom{8}{3}, \quad |A_4| = \binom{9}{3}.$$

The nonzero pairwise intersections have sizes

$$|A_1 \cap A_2| = \binom{6}{3}, \quad |A_1 \cap A_3| = \binom{3}{3}, \quad |A_1 \cap A_4| = \binom{4}{3},$$
$$|A_2 \cap A_3| = \binom{4}{3}, \quad |A_2 \cap A_4| = \binom{5}{3}.$$

All other pairwise intersections and all intersections of three or more of the A_i are empty. Therefore, by inclusion-exclusion, the required number is

$$\begin{aligned}\binom{15}{3} &- \left(\binom{10}{3} + \binom{11}{3} + \binom{8}{3} + \binom{9}{3}\right) \\ &+ \left(\binom{6}{3} + \binom{3}{3} + \binom{4}{3} + \binom{4}{3} + \binom{5}{3}\right) \\ &= 69.\end{aligned}$$

□

Problem 4. Let $n \in \mathbb{N}$ and $k \in \mathbb{Z}$ with $0 \le k \le n$. Prove that the number of k-element subsets of $[n]$ containing no two consecutive integers is

$$\binom{n-k+1}{k}.$$

We use the convention $\binom{a}{b} = 0$ when $a, b \in \mathbb{N}_0$ and $b > a$.

Solution. The case $k = 0$ is immediate. Assume $k \ge 1$, and write such a subset as

$$\{a_1 < a_2 < \cdots < a_k\}.$$

Since no two selected integers are consecutive,

$$a_{i+1} \ge a_i + 2$$

for every $1 \le i < k$. Define

$$b_i = a_i - (i-1), \qquad 1 \le i \le k.$$

Then

$$1 \le b_1 < b_2 < \cdots < b_k \le n - k + 1,$$

so $\{b_1, \ldots, b_k\}$ is a k-element subset of $[n-k+1]$.

Conversely, from any

$$1 \le b_1 < b_2 < \cdots < b_k \le n - k + 1,$$

defining $a_i = b_i + (i-1)$ gives a k-element subset of $[n]$ with no two consecutive elements. These constructions are inverse to each other. Hence the desired subsets are in bijection with the k-element subsets of $[n-k+1]$, and their number is

$$\binom{n-k+1}{k}.$$

□

Remark. The cyclic analogue is commonly known as *Cayley's problem*: one selects k vertices of a regular n-gon with no two selected vertices consecutive.

Problem 5. Let $n \in \mathbb{N}$. An n-derangement is a permutation $\pi \in S_n$ with no fixed point, i.e.

$$\pi(i) \neq i \qquad \text{for every } i \in [n].$$

Let D_n denote the number of n-derangements.

(a) Prove that

$$D_n = n! \sum_{k=0}^{n} \frac{(-1)^k}{k!}.$$

(b) Prove that, for every $n \geq 2$,

$$D_n = nD_{n-1} + (-1)^n.$$

Solution.

(a) For each $i \in [n]$, let

$$A_i = \{\pi \in S_n \mid \pi(i) = i\}.$$

The permutations that are not derangements are precisely the elements of $A_1 \cup \cdots \cup A_n$. For any distinct indices $i_1, \ldots, i_k$,

$$|A_{i_1} \cap \cdots \cap A_{i_k}| = (n-k)!,$$

since those k points are fixed and the remaining $n-k$ elements may be permuted arbitrarily. Hence inclusion-exclusion gives

$$\begin{aligned} |A_1 \cup \cdots \cup A_n| &= \sum_{k=1}^{n} (-1)^{k+1} \binom{n}{k} (n-k)! \\ &= n! \sum_{k=1}^{n} \frac{(-1)^{k+1}}{k!}. \end{aligned}$$

Therefore

$$\begin{aligned} D_n &= n! - |A_1 \cup \cdots \cup A_n| \\ &= n! \sum_{k=0}^{n} \frac{(-1)^k}{k!}. \end{aligned}$$

(b) Using part (a),

$$\begin{aligned} nD_{n-1} &= n! \sum_{k=0}^{n-1} \frac{(-1)^k}{k!} \\ &= n! \left(\sum_{k=0}^{n} \frac{(-1)^k}{k!} - \frac{(-1)^n}{n!} \right) \\ &= D_n - (-1)^n. \end{aligned}$$

Rearranging yields

$$D_n = nD_{n-1} + (-1)^n.$$

□